

Commercial alignment workflow (WIP)

Exec Summary

This document is an attempt to frame the “proposal / quote builder” space more strategically. Rather than treating it as a single product category, I find it more useful to view it as a commercial alignment workflow made up of distinct stages, each with its own depth of complexity. The stages span from context ingestion and draft assembly, through internal alignment and buyer collaboration, to commercial formalization, legal approvals, execution, and post-sign handoff. The key idea is that players in this space do not just differ in which stages they cover, but in how deeply they operate within each stage. For example, some products are strongest in buyer-facing collaboration and co-creation, while others are deeper in quote construction, legal control, or post-sign management. A stage × depth lens therefore provides a better way to compare the landscape than labels like “proposal builder,” “quote tool,” or “CLM.”

Using this framework, this document maps four adjacent players — GetAccept, PandaDoc, DocuSign, and Ironclad — to understand where each is strongest, where their boundaries blur, and where whitespace exists. The objective is not to decide our position yet, but to create a shared language for discussing where we may want to play and how deep we may want to go across the commercial alignment workflow. Please note that the competitor names are just indicative and by no means exhaustive.

While the idea for us is not to build anything and everything - it is important to clearly align on where will ‘exceed market expectations’, ‘Meet table stakes’ and ‘Play catch up’.

Landscape

Please refer to [Commercial agreement workflow](#) for a better readability of the below table. I found it more useful to frame this space as a stage × depth problem, not as a generic “proposal builder” or “quote builder” category. Stages represent the chronological flow from intake to signed and managed agreement. Depth represents how much rigor, complexity, and control a product can handle within each stage — from basic/manual to complex deals (enterprise-grade). For example, ‘ingestion of context’ can range from manual upload of call transcripts till programmable APIs from Gong feeding into Agents.

Depth of capabilities at each stage (4 being the highest)	Typical workflow from start to end						
		Ingestion of context	Draft Assembly	Internal Alignment	Buyer Presentation	Bilateral Shaping	Commercial Formalization
	0	No intake surface	No drafting support	No internal process	No buyer-facing layer	No collaboration	No commercial structure
	1	Manual upload or copy-paste	Static document creation	Ad hoc review	Send attachment or link	Accept or reject only	Manual price table
	2	Basic import from CRM, catalog, or files	Templates and variables	Simple approvals and comments	Hosted doc or page	Comments or simple edits	Structured quote or order form
	3	Structured prefill or system sync	Structured proposal, quote, or contract assembly	Multi-role routing and conditional approvals	Shared workspace with analytics	Live revisions, versioning, optional items, structured edits	Catalog-backed quote builder with approvals and options
	4	Programmable intake with	Dynamic assembly from catalog, rules,	Cross-functional orchestration	Persistent room with stakeholders,	Multi-party negotiation with controlled	Advanced configuration bundles, buy

		forms, APIs, and mapping	templates, and reusable blocks	with audit trail and policy logic	tasks, and guided progression	redlines and coordinated change management	selectable items, recurring terms, pricing logic
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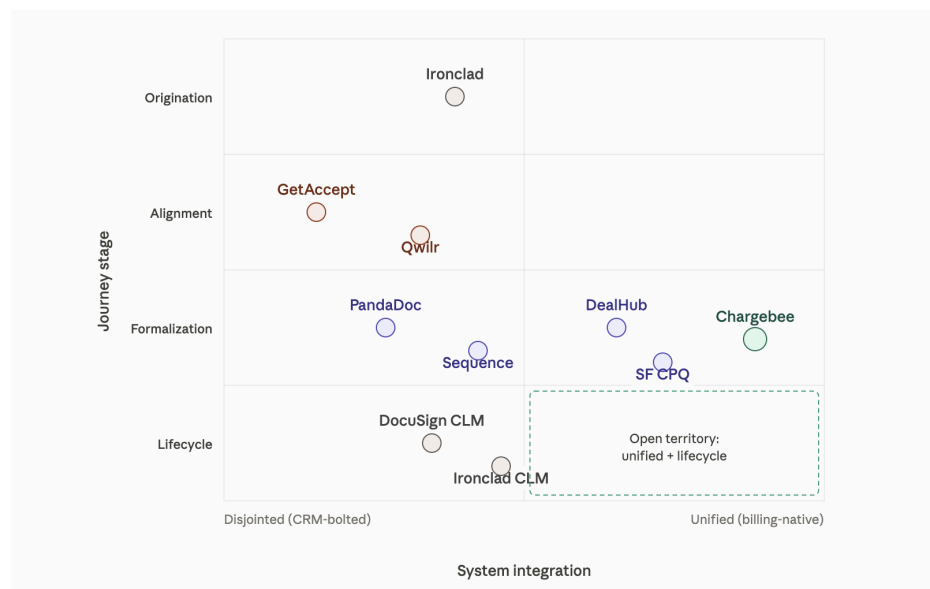
The below table talks about how the four players are positioned at each of the stages with 4 being the highest in feature depth. For example, in 'bilateral shaping' 'GetAccept' and 'PandaDoc' have maximum depth and hence are ranked 4 each.

The takeaway is:

- **GetAccept** is deepest in the **shared buyer workspace**
- **PandaDoc** is deepest in the **commercial document / quote system**
- **DocuSign** is deepest in the **agreement control system**
- **Ironclad** is deepest in the **contract workflow / intake and governance system**

	Ranked for depth across each stage (4 being the highest and 1 the lowest)			
Stage	GetAccept	PandaDoc	DocuSign	Ironclad
Seed / intake	1	2	3	4
Draft assembly	3	4	3	3
Internal alignment	2	3	4	4
Buyer presentation	4	4	1	1
Bilateral shaping	4	3	4	3
Commercial formalization	3	4	2	1
Legalization & approvals	1	2	4	4
Execution	3	3	4	3
Post-sign management & handoff	1	2	4	4

Positioning:



Main Jobs to be Done basis emerging from customer conversations:

Job 1: "Help me show the customer what they will pay, accurately."

The price-clarity job. Customers want a clean rendering of the commercial structure — line items, discounts, ramps, totals — that matches what the billing system will actually invoice.

- **Who's hiring it:** Every customer. This is the universal job.
- **What "good" looks like:** No drift between quote and invoice. Hybrid pricing renders cleanly. Multi-year deals don't surface confusing TCV summaries.
- **Who's currently doing it well:** No one fully. Chargebee is closest because of billing integration, but the PDF layout undermines it.

Job 2: "Let me make this document feel like ours, not the vendor's."

The branding-and-customization job. Customers want the quote to look like *their* commercial artifact — their logo, fonts, tone, structure — not a Chargebee-stamped output.

- **Who's hiring it:** Mid-market customers moving upmarket. Pauline (Brevo), Rachel (Appfire), Michelle, Nandha.
- **What "good" looks like:** Visual control, header/footer flexibility, layout control, brand assets.
- **Who's currently doing it well:** PandaDoc, GetAccept, Qwilr. Chargebee currently doesn't.

Job 3: "Make sure the right legal language shows up for this specific deal."

The conditional-clauses job. Customers in regulated/multi-entity setups need clauses that vary by jurisdiction, entity, customer type, deal size.

- **Who's hiring it:** Multi-entity SaaS (Brevo's GmbH/SAS/Inc pattern), enterprise sellers, EU+US sellers.
- **What "good" looks like:** Rule-based clause swapping. Legal-owned clause library. Smart rules tied to deal attributes.
- **Who's currently doing it well:** PandaDoc Smart Content, RevOps.io, Ironclad. Chargebee doesn't do this at all.

Job 4: "Capture the deal as a legal commitment that survives lifecycle changes."

The contract-of-record job. The PDF needs to function as the legal artifact — including across renewals, amendments, expansions.

- **Who's hiring it:** Subscription-mature customers — Morten/David at their company, Brendan Mitchell, Naveen, Monica Lazzaro Kuhliger.
- **What "good" looks like:** A quote that knows it's an amendment, expresses proration cleanly, references the parent subscription.
- **Who's currently doing it well:** No one. CLM tools (Ironclad, DocuSign CLM) handle contracts but not pricing math. CPQ tools generate fresh quotes that ignore lifecycle.
- **This is your most defensible job.**

Job 5: "Make my sales rep faster — fewer fields, fewer approvals, more autonomy."

The seller-velocity job. Reps want speed; admins want guardrails. The PDF/quote process either accelerates or blocks them.

- **Who's hiring it:** Every Sales-led customer. Brendan Mitchell, Vic, Joel Neutzner.
- **What "good" looks like:** Fast quote creation, in-CRM workflow, no re-keying, instant preview.
- **Who's currently doing it well:** PandaDoc, DealHub, HubSpot Quotes. Chargebee is mid-pack here.

Job 6: "Help my buyer understand and act on the quote."

The buyer-engagement job. Get the buyer to read it, understand it, sign it, pay.

- **Who's hiring it:** Brevo, customers comparing GetAccept-style tools.
- **What "good" looks like:** Shared workspace, comments, video, view analytics, e-sign in flow.

- **Who's currently doing it well:** GetAccept, PandaDoc, Qwilr.
- **Probably NOT your job to fight for.** This is downstream-of-positioning, but worth flagging.

Job	# of calls	% of signal-calls	# unique customer speakers
J5: Make sales rep faster	73	92%	94
J1: Price clarity / matches invoice	72	91%	99
J4: Contract-of-record through lifecycle	47	60%	57
J3: Right legal language per deal	22	28%	28
J6: Buyer engagement	18	23%	22
J2: Branding/customization	17	22%	17

Main job	Main job %	Sub-job	Sub-job %
J5 — Make sales rep faster	92%	J5a — Quote creation speed in CRM	71%
		J5c — Avoid re-keying / Word workarounds	59%
		J5b — Approval flow automation	48%
J1 — Price clarity / matches the bill	91%	J1c — Ramps and phased pricing render cleanly	56%
		J1a — Hybrid / usage-based renders cleanly	12%
		J1b — Multi-year total / TCV legible	11%
J4 — Contract-of-record through lifecycle	60%	J4b — Mid-cycle amendment / add-on quote	20%
		J4e — Proration display legibility	12%
		J4a — Renewal quote for active subscription	7%
		J4d — Renewal with price increase	4%
J3 — Right legal language per deal	28%	J3a — Static T&C block in quote	11%
		J3b — Conditional clauses by entity/geo	4%
J6 — Buyer engagement	23%	J6a — Send / track / view analytics	6%
		J6b — Shared workspace / collaboration	6%
J2 — Make doc feel like ours (branding/customization)	22%	J2a — Visual brand assets	10%
		J2c — Layout / field reordering	10%
		J2b — Rich text inside notes	1%

Excerpts from customer conversations:

Pain Point	Context & Strategic Impact	Source Context
The "Scary Box" (Header Summary)	More psychological than anything else: Placement of Total Contract Value (TCV) at the top of quotes triggers procurement thresholds and executive approval cycles prematurely, stalling deals. The final value right at the top is too much of a shock at the beginning.	Appfire (Rachel Miner)
Restrictive Character Limits	A 2,000-character limit on quote notes is insufficient for including complex Terms & Conditions (T&Cs) or redlined negotiated clauses.	Appfire (Rachel Miner)
Lack of Rich Text Editing	Inability to use bolding, headers, or tables in notes results in "smushed," unprofessional documents that are difficult for legal teams to parse.	Appfire / Becki Harris
Semantic Labeling Confusion	Standard labels like "Shipped to" are ill-suited for SaaS; "First billing cycle" is misleading when applied to midterm upgrades or amendments.	Appfire / Revolves
Manual Calculation Loops	Reliance on external Excel spreadsheets to calculate complex tiered volume pricing because internal CPQ mechanisms are too rigid.	Revolves (Bruna Ferreira)
E-Signature "Unreadability"	Not entirely relevant to the context: Generated PDFs often lack a recognizable text layer, forcing sales reps to manually	Pb Team (Madhu Babu Bhashyam)

Pain Point	Context & Strategic Impact	Source Context
	drag-and-drop signature blocks in tools like DocuSign or Adobe Sign.	
System "Tricking" for Renewals	Inability to create renewal quotes for active plans requires users to manually set subscriptions to "non-renewing" just to trigger a quote.	Tabularity
Redundant Line Item Views	For non-standard durations (e.g., 9-month construction projects), systems often duplicate line items 9 times instead of providing a milestone view.	Galen.I
Legal Entity Mismatches	Challenges in dynamically swapping entity-based legal sentences (e.g., GmbH vs. SAS vs. Inc.) based on the customer's billing country.	Brevo (Alexandre)
Marketing vs. Billing IDs	Discrepancies between marketing names on quotes and obscure internal SKUs on invoices lead to friction with customer finance departments.	Brevo (Alexandre)

The triggers that determine how a Quote template could manifest fall into 4 broad buckets:

1. Product/ Configuration data
2. Financial/ commercial data
3. Compliance/ Jurisdiction data
4. Relationship/ Behavioral data

Use cases WIP

Category	Input Condition (The "IF")	Document Outcome (The "THEN")	Strategic Implication
Financial	ACV > \$50k AND Industry == "SaaS"	Appends "Professional Services" SOW and "Implementation Fees"	Prevents revenue leakage by ensuring service fees are included in mid-market deals.
Financial	Discount > 20%	Early termination penalty	Protects long-term margin in exchange for upfront pricing concessions.
Financial	Payment Terms == "Net 60"	Late fee penalty clause for non standard payment terms	Mitigates cash flow risk associated with extended payment cycles.
Product	SKU contains "managed_security"	Attaches "SOC 2 Type II" and "PCI-DSS" compliance certifications as exhibits.	Streamlines security review by proactively providing proof of compliance.
Product	If SKU/ Product Contains XX	Trigger inclusion of 24/7 SLAs Installation clauses	
Product	Hardware SKU selected	Inserts "Warranty & RMA Policy" and "On-Site Maintenance" terms.	Ensures physical goods are covered by the correct return and service legalities.
Legal	Jurisdiction == "EU"	Swaps "US Choice of Law" for "Luxembourg" and inserts GDPR DPA.	Ensures jurisdictional enforceability and regional data privacy compliance. Note: There could be appendages or swaps in legal language
Legal	Contract term = XX	Auto renewal clauses	Protects future revenue by formalizing the renewal window.
Legal	Multi year deals	Material adverse change (MAC) clause	
Legal	Industry == XX (Health care)	Add Hippa compliance	
Legal	Industry == "Public Sector"	Appends "Federal Acquisition Regulation" (FAR) and "Buy American" clauses.	Meets strict government procurement requirements automatically.

UX patterns observed:

Three/ four meaningfully different UX models exist in the market . They map to different beliefs about who the user is and how much complexity they tolerate:

Model	Best example	Admin's mental model	Where it breaks	Takeaway
Visual rule builder on a content block	PandaDoc Smart Content	"I drop a placeholder, then attach if/then rules to it"	Multi-variable AND/OR logic, debugging, scale	This is the pattern most non-technical RevOps admins will recognize and finish setting up unaided. It's a strong default. The footguns are real but addressable — we can do better than first-match-wins with explicit AND/OR and a "rule simulator" preview pane
Inline templating DSL (Handlebars-style)	RevOps.io	"I write the contract once, with conditional snippets inline"	Non-technical users, version drift, reviewability	Quasi-developer mindset needed. This is the model that works only for the top 10% of complex deals and the wrong default for the other 90%. It maps perfectly to a deal desk owner's mental model but excludes the average RevOps admin. Feels like writing endless prose with if else conditions
Tag + condition on selected text	Ironclad / Juro	"I write the doc, highlight a span, attach a condition"	Pricing/numeric logic, deep CPQ integration	This is the <i>gold standard</i> for legal-driven conditional clauses. Interesting concepts of (a) conditions as named first-class objects, (b) clause library decoupling, and (c) visual marking of conditional spans inside the editor.
Flag-based section toggle	Salesforce CPQ	"I create a checkbox/formula on the quote, point a section at it"	Anyone who isn't a Salesforce admin	
Notion-like editor with variables only	Sequence	"Variables auto-fill, I duplicate templates for variants"	Low — no real conditional logic. Editor philosophy prevents rules/condition approach	Startup-friendly, Notion-like, billing-truth-aware — and they have a <i>visible gap</i> exactly where you're building. If we ship rule-driven conditional content with a Notion-style editor, we leapfrog them on that dimension

Visual representation:

Pandadoc:

4. Governing Law & Jurisdiction

This agreement is governed by the laws of the jurisdiction specified below. Any disputes shall be resolved exclusively in the courts of that jurisdiction.

♦ SMART CONTENT

[Conditional governing law clause — populated when document is generated based on customer's country variable]

The prevailing party in any dispute shall be entitled to recover reasonable attorneys' fees and costs.

▼ RULES • 3 ACTIVE

1 EU customer → DPA clause

VARIABLE

customer.country

OPERATOR

is one of

VALUE

DE, FR, NL, IE, ES, IT

SHOW

EU Governing Law + GDPR DPA

2 California customer

VARIABLE

customer.state

OPERATOR

equals

VALUE

California

Sequence

Order Form • {Customer name}

This Order Form is between Provider and {Customer name}, with billing address {Customer address}, {Customer country}.

Contract term: {Contract duration}, starting {Start date} and ending {End date}.

Payment terms: {Payment terms}. All amounts in {Currency}.

[Governing law clause goes here — currently hardcoded to Delaware. For EU customers, duplicate this template, rename it "EU MSA", and manually rewrite this paragraph.]

TYPE "/" TO INSERT A BLOCK

Text

Heading

List

Image

Pricing block

Cover image

Iron clad:

PROPERTIES	
• Jurisdiction	
• Industry	
• Contract Value	
• Term Months	
CONDITIONS	
• IsEU	
• IsHealthcare	
• IsEnterprise	
• IsMultiYear	
CLAUSE LIBRARY	
GDPR DPA	
HIPAA BAA	
MAC Clause	

Master Service Agreement

This Master Service Agreement is entered into between Provider and the Customer named on the Order Form. _____

4. Governing Law. This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of Ireland, and the parties submit to the exclusive jurisdiction of the Irish courts. A Data Processing Addendum compliant with GDPR is attached as Exhibit B.

This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Delaware, USA, and the parties submit to the exclusive jurisdiction of the Delaware courts.

5. Data Handling. Provider maintains industry-standard security controls. A HIPAA Business Associate Agreement is attached as Exhibit C and incorporated by reference.

6. Term. This Agreement may be terminated upon a Material Adverse Change as defined

▼ SELECTED CONDITION · ISEU

Condition formula

EXPRESSION

In(Jurisdiction, ["DE", "FR", "NL", "IE", "ES", "IT", "BE", "AT"])

Used in

DOCUMENTS

3 templates

APPROVERS

1 routing rule

CLAUSES

2 conditional spans

Revops

TERM · GOVERNING LAW (MARKDOWN · OPERATORS ENABLED)

```
// Branches based on the GoverningTerms dropdown property {{#eq
current.term.properties.GoverningTerms.value "Online ToS"}} By
executing this Order Form, Customer agrees to be bound by the RevOps
Terms of Service available at https://revops.io/terms in effect as of
the Effective Date. {{/eq}} {{#eq
current.term.properties.GoverningTerms.value "Attached MSA"}} This
Agreement incorporates the attached Master Service Agreement which
contains warranty disclaimers and liability limitations. {{/eq}} //
Math + date logic inline - compute TCV, format Q4 promotion window
Total Contract Value: ${{multiply deal.term.monthlyFee
deal.term.months}} {{#switch deal.contract.formType}} {{#case
"renewal"}}Thank you for your continued partnership.{{/case}} {{#case
"new-order"}}We're excited to start this partnership.{{/case}}
{{/switch}}
```

Prototype: <https://lovable.dev/projects/8f9433c6-a3f1-4f39-a57b-dce07fe3e261>

Preliminary thoughts on next steps (WIP):

(Way too early to finalize this section. This section will keep evolving as discussions unfold on goals, what we build, for what level of deal complexity, why and other such questions—as we incrementally and quickly keep iterating)

Broadly, we need to decide — **At what stage and what depth do we want to be and by when** — & consciously choosing which we want to avoid competing in

I don't think we should frame this as "a lite DSR" or "a lite CLM." That makes us sound like a partial version of adjacent categories. The better framing is that we are building a **billing-native commercial execution platform**. DSR tools are

optimized to help sellers and buyers align on the deal. CLM tools are optimized to help companies control and govern contracts. Our job is different: to turn commercial context into a signable, activation-ready agreement with minimal translation loss into subscriptions, billing, and revenue. We will borrow selected patterns from both DSR and CLM, but our center of gravity is neither — it is commercial execution into monetization

We can broadly work on the below goals:

- From transactional gatekeeper to commercial alignment builder
 - From just inward-facing to outward-facing
- From a Quote form to a commercial canvas

The three board pillars for short term (WIP):

1. **Agentic context ingestor:** The missing wedge today is the jump from messy context into a clean commercial artifact.
 - a. **What capabilities can it provide?**
 - i. Programmatic ingestion of context from call transcripts and enterprise data silos (Salesforce)
 - ii. Produce a quote skeleton
 - iii. Show confidence and source for each filed
 - b. **What will it result in?**
 - i. Minimize context loss
 - ii. Grafting winning narratives (potential objections/ battle cards)
 - iii. Start off with Pre populated quote relevant to the context than a generic template
2. **Commercial canvas**
 - a. **What capabilities can it provide?**
 - i. A web-based, block-oriented editor inspired by Notion and Sequence. Everything in this canvas is a "block" that can be moved, transformed, or dynamically updated.
 - ii. Media block, pricing block, narrative block, legal block
 - iii. Important note: The goal is not to compete with Notion/ Sequence/ deal hub etc. Rather the canvas will provide more customization capabilities on quote creation (rather than a fancy proposal making) at least for the MVP
 - b. **What will it result in?**
 - i. Exec summaries written from call transcripts
 - ii. Pricing modeling with what if scenarios
 - iii. Simple drag drop blocks that are aligned to narrative
 - iv. Legal clauses basis rules (Enterprise deals, data privacy clauses etc.)
3. **Collaborative deal room:** Chargebee's quote link must transform into a persistent, collaborative environment to co-create the deal
 - a. Add comments to the deals
 - b. Invite stakeholders
 - c. AI agents can guide on negotiations